

SHOGI · VARIANT 15 OF 24

Kyoto Shogi

5×5
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

KYOTO SHOGI

Kyoto Shogi was invented by Tamiya Katsuya around 1976. It is played on a 5×5 board, and every piece except the King represents a pair: after each move, the moved piece must flip to show its other face. The game name plays on the pairing of the Japanese pronunciation of Kyoto (, Kyō-to) with piece name components. Public domain.



Kyoto Shogi — starting position

SETUP

Board: 5×5 grid, 25 squares.

Pieces per player: 5 (King + 4 dual-sided pieces).

Starting position:

PLAYER	RANK	PIECES (FILES 5–1, LEFT TO RIGHT)
White (top)	Rank 5	Pawn · Gold · King · Silver · Token
Black (bottom)	Rank 1	Token · Silver · King · Gold · Pawn

Black (Sente) moves first. The position is point-symmetric (180-degree rotation).

PIECE PAIRS

Each non-King piece has two faces. The piece flips to its alternate face after every move, mandatory.

FACE A	FACE B
Token (と)	Lance ()
Silver General ()	Bishop ()
Gold General ()	Knight ()
Pawn ()	Rook ()

Piece movements:

PIECE	MOVEMENT
King	One square in any direction
Token	One step orthogonally or diagonally forward (Gold General movement)
Lance	Any number of squares forward only
Silver General	One step diagonally, or one step forward
Bishop	Any number of squares diagonally
Gold General	One step orthogonally or diagonally forward
Knight	Jumps two squares forward and one sideways
Pawn	One step forward
Rook	Any number of squares orthogonally

THE FLIP RULE

After every move, the moved piece must flip to its alternate face. A piece may be moved to a square from which it would immediately have no legal move (for example, a Lance on the final rank that will flip to a Token on the next turn) — this is legal in Kyoto Shogi, unlike Standard Shogi.

DROPS

Captured pieces may be dropped back onto any empty square. When dropping, the player chooses which face of the pair to place face-up.

WIN CONDITION

Checkmate the opponent's King.

DRAWS

The same position occurring three times with the same player to move is a draw.

ATTRIBUTION

Kyoto Shogi. Invented by Tamiya Katsuya, c. 1976. Rules published freely since at least the 1980s; game mechanics are not copyrightable. Sources: pychess.org/variants/kyotoshogi; Fairy-Stockfish variants.ini engine definition.